project. Every year from 2003, in the torrid heat of a Gujarat summer, IAS officers would fan out to convince parents to send their children, especially girls, to school. Modi himself had laid out the blueprint. In his book *Centrestage*, Ahmedabad-based journalist Uday Mahurkar says that Modi told his officers, 'Why should a child cry when she goes to school for the first time? We need to bring a smile on their face.' Cultural programmes were started to make the toddlers feel at home in school. Dropout rates fell and the enrolment percentage rose from 74 to 99.25 per cent in a decade. 'Why don't you show positive stories about Gujarat? *Kab tak negative dikhate rahoge*?' (How long will you keep showing only negatives?), Modi asked me on more than one occasion.

It seemed as though Modi wanted to constantly prove a point. The riots had left a big question mark on his administrative capability, and he now wanted to undo the damage. This wasn't just about his national ambitions—it was also about conquering the demons that nestled within, a yearning to prove his critics wrong.

An interesting aspect of this was Modi's relationship with industry, well documented in a *Caravan* magazine profile in 2012. In March 2002, barely a few weeks after the riots, at a Confederation of Indian Industry (CII) meet in Ahmedabad, Cyrus Guzder, a much-respected industrialist, had raised a pointed question—'Is secularism good for business?'—and likened the attacks on Muslim homes to a 'genocide'. It didn't stop there. I was speaking at a panel discussion at the CII annual summit in Delhi in April 2002 on 'Gujarat at the Crossroads' when Anu Aga of the Thermax group, who later became a member of Sonia Gandhi's National Advisory Council, lashed out, 'The Gujarat riots have shamed all of us.' She got a standing ovation from an audience that is normally very careful in displaying its political preferences openly.

In February 2003, the confrontation between Modi and industry appeared to worsen. Rahul Bajaj and Jamshed Godrej, two of the country's seniormost corporate leaders, spoke out on the 2002 riots in the presence of the Gujarat chief minister. Describing 2002 as a 'lost year' for Gujarat,